

Pathway to Entry

Consultation Report

Understanding the transition gap between post-school aspiration, pathway choice, and actual entry

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This is an independent youth-led consultation report prepared for publication by Pathway to Entry. It is intended to inform youth-led advocacy, stakeholder engagement, school and provider conversations, and the further development of practical transition supports for young people. It should not be read as an official government position unless separately endorsed by the relevant body.

Publication note

This report has been prepared as a formal publication version of the Pathway to Entry consultation findings. It uses a plain black-and-white layout, numbered chapters, numbered figures and tables, and a conventional reference section so that it can be published, printed, sent to stakeholders, or used as supporting evidence in applications and grant materials.

All survey results are reported in aggregate. Identifying fields were excluded from analysis. The qualitative extracts used in this report are anonymised and are included only to illustrate recurring themes. Percentages are calculated out of all 200 consented responses unless otherwise stated. Because respondents could select more than one barrier or support type, multi-select totals exceed 100 percent.

Abstract

Pathway to Entry investigated the barriers faced by young people in moving from post-school intention to actual entry into university, TAFE, apprenticeships, traineeships, employment, and related pathways. The consultation received 200 consented responses. The findings indicate that the problem is not simply a lack of aspiration. The dominant pattern is a transition-navigation failure: young people are being asked to make high-stakes decisions across fragmented information systems, unclear deadlines, administrative complexity, cost pressure, transport constraints, and uneven access to industry exposure or mentoring.

The strongest survey result was limited information, selected by 140 respondents (70.0 percent). The strongest requested support was clearer timelines, selected by 142 respondents (71.0 percent). Application timing or complexity was selected by 119 respondents (59.5 percent), while cost or financial pressure was selected by 107 respondents (53.5 percent). These findings support a practical intervention model: Pathway to Entry should act as a youth-facing transition navigation layer that centralises timelines, application guidance, financial support information, local exposure opportunities, mentoring, and referrals into an accessible system.

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Executive Summary

Pathway to Entry was established to address a specific gap in post-school transition support: the distance between a young person's pathway intention and their actual entry into further education, training, work, or another meaningful destination. The consultation results show that this gap is not primarily caused by low ambition. It is caused by weak navigation infrastructure.

The 200 consented responses show a consistent pattern. Young people can often name broad post-school options, but they struggle to translate those options into an ordered sequence of deadlines, forms, eligibility rules, costs, supports, transport requirements, documents, contacts, and realistic next steps. The result is avoidable friction. Some students delay applications. Some narrow their ambitions too early. Some choose the option that feels easiest to access rather than the option that best fits their interests, capacity, and long-term goals.

The report's central finding is therefore:

**The transition problem is not simply a motivation problem. It is a navigation problem.
Young people need a clearer system for moving from aspiration to action.**

Table 1: Headline findings and implications

Finding	Evidence	Implication
Limited information is the dominant barrier	140 respondents (70.0%) selected limited information.	The first design priority should be a single, plain-English pathway navigator rather than another motivational campaign.
Timelines are the clearest unmet support need	142 respondents (71.0%) selected clearer timelines.	Students need to know what to do, when to do it, and what documents, costs and contacts are required.
Administrative complexity is a major hidden obstacle	119 respondents (59.5%) selected application timing or complexity.	Application walkthroughs, deadline reminders and worked examples should be core infrastructure.
Cost is a structural rather than marginal barrier	107 respondents (53.5%) selected cost or financial pressure.	Financial support information should be treated as pathway information, not an optional add-on.
Exposure and social capital remain uneven	90 respondents (45.0%) wanted employer or industry exposure; 44 respondents (22.0%) wanted mentoring or role models.	Pathway confidence should be built through direct contact with providers, workers, graduates and local employers.

The report recommends that Pathway to Entry should not try to replace schools, careers advisers, TAFE, universities, employers, youth services or government programs. Its strongest role is connective: to translate, sequence and centralise existing information and supports into a youth-accessible pathway navigation model. This would make the current system easier to use, especially for regional students who face greater distance, weaker access to in-person exposure, and fewer informal networks.

The proposed intervention model has six components:

1. a central pathway calendar and checklist;
2. application walkthroughs and worked examples;

3. a financial support and scholarship navigator;
4. regional transport, accommodation and access guidance;
5. employer, provider and industry exposure opportunities;
6. a mentoring and referral system connecting young people to people who have already navigated similar pathways.

The consultation supports a practical next stage: publish the report, build a public-facing resource hub, pilot workshops with schools and youth services, develop partner referral arrangements, and evaluate whether students become more confident, better informed, and more likely to complete concrete pathway actions.

1. Introduction

1.1. Purpose of the report

This report converts the Pathway to Entry consultation results into a structured evidence base. Its purpose is to move the project from a broad idea into a defensible intervention: a practical youth-led system for reducing the barriers between pathway choice and pathway entry.

The report is designed for four audiences. First, it is for young people and students who need their transition experiences taken seriously. Second, it is for schools, youth services, providers and employers that already work near this problem but may not see the full transition journey from the student's perspective. Third, it is for government and community stakeholders who need evidence about what is missing between policy intention and youth experience. Fourth, it is for Pathway to Entry itself as a strategic foundation for publishing resources, seeking partnerships, and measuring future impact.

1.2. The transition gap

Most discussion about post-school pathways focuses on aspiration, career education, or broad destination categories. Those categories matter, but they do not fully capture the problem identified in this consultation. The difficult point is often not deciding that a pathway is desirable. The difficult point is turning that pathway into a completed action.

A young person may want to apply for university, enrol in TAFE, seek an apprenticeship, attend an interview, pursue a traineeship, or enter work. Each of those pathways contains hidden steps. The student must know what website to use, what deadline applies, what documents are required, what costs may arise, what concessions exist, what scholarships are open, how to travel to an open day or interview, who can answer questions, and what to do if the first pathway fails. If any part of that sequence is unclear, the pathway becomes fragile.

This is what the report calls the *transition gap*: the space between intention and entry. It is the part of the system where motivation must become paperwork, deadlines, transport, money, communication, confidence, and follow-through.

1.3. Why the issue matters for regional young people

The consultation is especially relevant to regional young people because regionality compounds ordinary transition barriers. Information is still fragmented for metropolitan students, but regional students also face

distance from providers, fewer local open days, fewer nearby industry exposure opportunities, higher travel costs, weaker public transport options, and sometimes smaller peer groups pursuing the same pathway. These factors do not remove aspiration; they make action harder.

National and NSW policy already recognise parts of this issue. The Australian Universities Accord Final Report was released in February 2024 with 47 recommendations intended to shape long-term higher education reform and meet future skills needs [1]. Australian Government higher education statistics for 2024 show that students from regional and remote areas remain underrepresented: they accounted for 20.1 percent of domestic commencing students and 19.2 percent of enrolled domestic students, compared with 27.1 percent of the Australian population living in regional and remote areas [2]. NSW policy also emphasises that students need consistent and equitable access to resources, guidance and support so they can make informed decisions and transition into suitable post-school destinations [3].

Pathway to Entry sits inside that policy problem. It is not a substitute for systemic reform. It is a practical response to a measurable failure in the lived experience of transition.

1.4. Central argument

The report's argument is deliberately narrow:

Regional young people do not only need more encouragement to pursue post-school pathways. They need a clearer, earlier, more practical and more continuous system for navigating the steps between interest and entry.

This argument matters because it changes the solution. If the problem is assumed to be low aspiration, the answer becomes inspiration campaigns. If the problem is actually navigation failure, the answer becomes timelines, checklists, application guidance, financial navigation, exposure, mentoring and local referral systems. The consultation results strongly support the second interpretation.

2. Methodology

2.1. Data source

The report is based on the Pathway to Entry consultation survey. The dataset contained 200 valid responses. All 200 respondents consented to their views and ideas being used to inform the project. The survey was completed on 20 April 2026.

The analysis excluded identifying fields. Email entries were anonymous and name fields were blank or not used for reporting. The report therefore treats the data as an anonymised consultation dataset rather than an individually identifiable survey.

2.2. Survey structure

The survey collected information across the following areas:

- age group;
- region;
- current situation;

- whether the respondent had chosen a pathway after school;
- chosen pathway type, where applicable;
- perceived barriers between choosing a pathway and reaching entry;
- the hardest step in the pathway process;
- supports that would have made the biggest difference;
- what respondents believed was missing in current advice or support;
- consent for use of responses.

Barrier and support questions allowed multiple selections. This design is appropriate because pathway barriers rarely occur in isolation. A respondent may face limited information, application complexity and cost pressure at the same time. For this reason, multi-select results should be read as prevalence indicators rather than mutually exclusive categories.

2.3. Analytical approach

The analysis used three layers.

First, each structured response was counted and converted into a percentage of the 200 valid responses. This produced the main quantitative findings on respondent profile, pathway status, selected barriers and selected support needs.

Second, qualitative responses were coded into recurring themes. The coding focused on the main practical problem described in each response, such as information, applications, cost, transport, confidence, calendars, exposure, mentoring or financial support. Because some qualitative responses used recurring wording, qualitative results are interpreted as thematic signals rather than as unique interview quotations.

Third, the consultation findings were interpreted against relevant policy context. This included higher education participation data, NSW pathways strategy material, the Regional Industry Education Partnerships program, and NSW pathway data initiatives. The purpose was not to prove causation from a small consultation sample, but to place the consultation results inside a broader and already recognised transition problem.

2.4. Limitations

The report has several limitations.

1. **The sample is consultative, not representative.** The 200 responses provide useful evidence for project design and advocacy, but they should not be presented as statistically representative of all regional young people in NSW.
2. **The respondent mix is uneven.** The sample includes students, university participants, TAFE participants, employed young people, recent graduates, and educators or stakeholders. This gives breadth, but it also means that findings are not limited to one cohort.
3. **Some qualitative responses use recurring wording.** This suggests that responses may have been shaped by survey design, prompts, or repeated phrasing. The report therefore uses qualitative responses cautiously as thematic evidence rather than treating every phrase as a unique narrative.

4. **The survey identifies perceived barriers, not administrative outcome data.** It shows what respondents experienced or believed was difficult. It does not directly measure application completion rates, enrolment rates or long-term employment outcomes.
5. **Regional scope requires further validation.** Although 118 respondents were based in Regional NSW, further consultation with schools, youth services, families, TAFE, universities, employers and specific regional communities would strengthen future reporting.

These limitations do not undermine the report's usefulness. They clarify what kind of evidence it provides. The consultation is strong enough to guide a pilot intervention and stakeholder discussion. It should be strengthened over time with more targeted consultation and outcome measurement.

3. Respondent Profile

3.1. Overview

The respondent profile matters because the consultation is not only a school-student survey. It captures a mixed set of views from young people and stakeholders at different stages of the transition process. This is useful because the transition gap can be seen from multiple positions: before leaving school, while applying, while entering TAFE or university, while working, or after recently graduating.

Table 2: Age group of respondents

Category	n	% of respondents
16–18	50	25.0%
18–23	94	47.0%
Educator / stakeholder	31	15.5%
Prefer not to say	25	12.5%

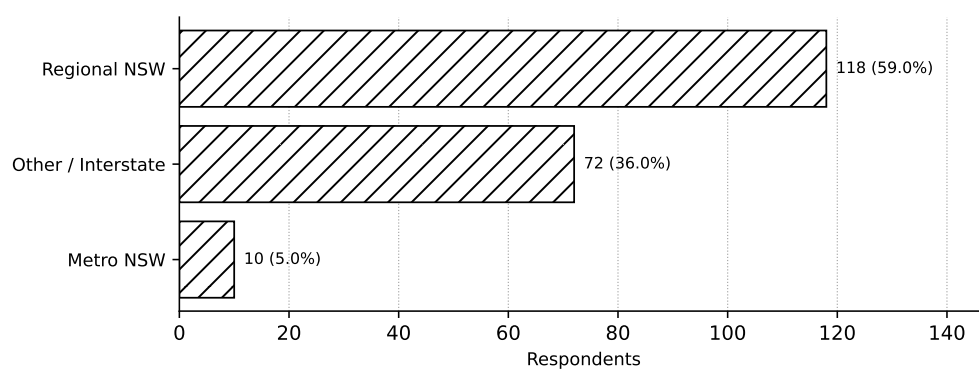
Table 3: Region of respondents

Category	n	% of respondents
Regional NSW	118	59.0%
Other / Interstate	72	36.0%
Metro NSW	10	5.0%

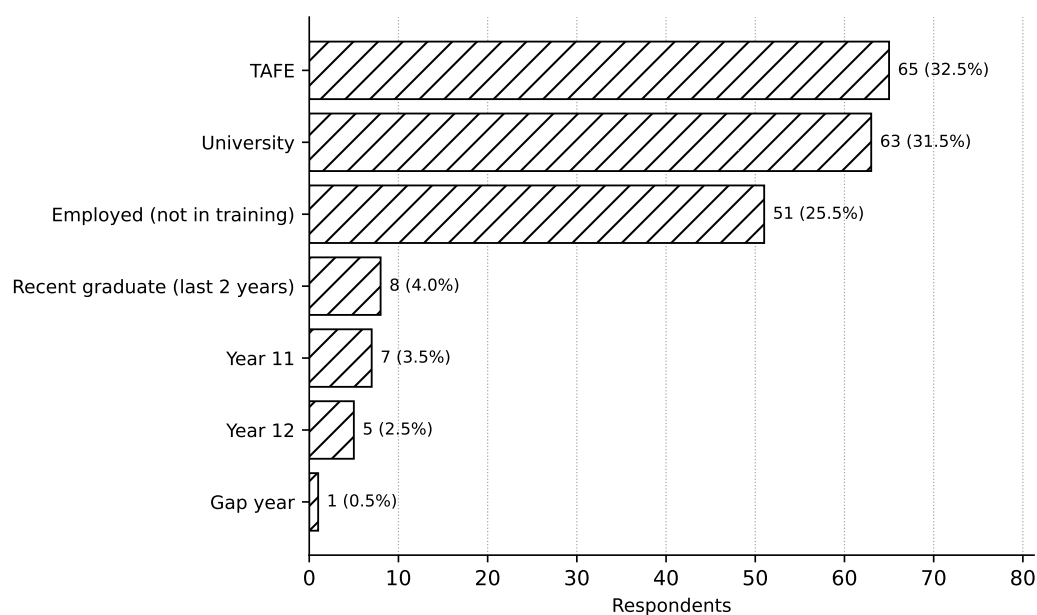
The regional profile is particularly important. A majority of respondents were based in Regional NSW, while a substantial group selected Other or Interstate. This means the findings should be interpreted as strongly relevant to regional transition issues, but not limited only to one local government area or one school community.

3.2. Current situation

The current situation results show a consultation sample that includes people already in post-school pathways. This is valuable because respondents who have entered university, TAFE or employment can identify barriers from lived experience rather than only from expectation.

**Figure 1:** Respondent region**Table 4:** Current situation of respondents

Category	n	% of respondents
TAFE	65	32.5%
University	63	31.5%
Employed (not in training)	51	25.5%
Recent graduate (last 2 years)	8	4.0%
Year 11	7	3.5%
Year 12	5	2.5%
Gap year	1	0.5%

**Figure 2:** Current situation of respondents

The largest groups were TAFE participants, university participants and employed respondents not currently in training. This profile supports the report's focus on transition infrastructure rather than only career inspiration. Many respondents were close enough to the process to identify practical barriers such as deadlines, forms, financial information and transport.

4. Pathway Status and Direction

4.1. Whether respondents had chosen a pathway

A central question for Pathway to Entry is whether young people have already chosen a pathway after school. The results show that more than half had chosen a pathway, but a large minority remained unsure.

Table 5: Whether respondents had chosen a pathway after school

Category	n	% of respondents
Yes	114	57.0%
Unsure	75	37.5%
No	11	5.5%

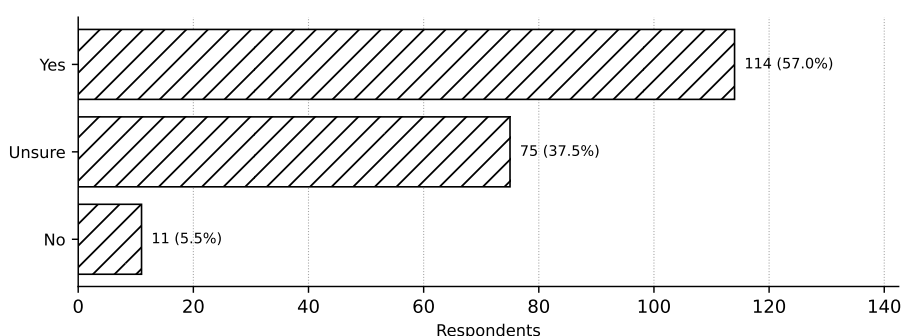


Figure 3: Pathway decision status

The result is strategically important. The 75 unsure respondents are not necessarily disengaged. Many may be active decision-makers who lack sufficient information, exposure or confidence to convert interest into commitment. Pathway to Entry should therefore avoid treating uncertainty as failure. Uncertainty is often a rational response to incomplete information.

4.2. Chosen pathway type

Among respondents who identified a pathway, the most common pathway categories were TAFE, university and employment.

This distribution reinforces a key design point: Pathway to Entry should not be a university-only project. A credible pathway navigation model must include university, TAFE, apprenticeships, traineeships, employment, bridging options, alternative entry, scholarships and local industry exposure. A university-only framing would be too narrow and would weaken the project's credibility with schools and youth services.

Table 6: Chosen pathway type

Category	n	% of respondents
TAFE	45	22.5%
University	41	20.5%
Employment	27	13.5%
Not sure	1	0.5%
No response	86	43.0%

The 'No response' category largely reflects respondents who had not chosen a pathway or selected 'Unsure' or 'No' on the preceding question.

5. Major Consultation Findings

5.1. Finding 1: limited information is the dominant barrier

The strongest barrier result was limited information, selected by 140 respondents, or 70.0 percent of the sample. This is the clearest evidence for the report's central argument. The problem is not simply that young people do not care about their future. It is that information is scattered across websites, institutions, application portals, schools, providers, employers and informal networks.

Table 7: Selected barriers between choosing a pathway and reaching entry

Category	n	% of respondents
Limited information	140	70.0%
Application timing or complexity	119	59.5%
Cost or financial pressure	107	53.5%
Travel / distance	75	37.5%
Confidence	48	24.0%

Respondents could select multiple barriers, so percentages do not add to 100.

Limited information should be interpreted broadly. It includes not knowing what pathway options exist, not knowing the steps required for a chosen pathway, not knowing relevant deadlines, not knowing what documents are needed, not knowing what financial supports exist, and not knowing who can answer specific questions. In practice, these categories overlap.

The high information result also suggests that the current support landscape is too fragmented from the user perspective. A school may have a careers adviser. A university may have an admissions site. TAFE may have course pages. Government may have scholarships or support programs. Employers may have apprenticeships. But if a young person cannot see how these elements fit together into a sequence of action, the existence of separate supports does not solve the transition problem.

5.2. Finding 2: application timing and complexity create hidden friction

Application timing or complexity was selected by 119 respondents, or 59.5 percent. This is one of the most important findings because it identifies the hidden administrative burden of post-school transition. Applications are not neutral. They require literacy, confidence, timing, digital access, document organisation,

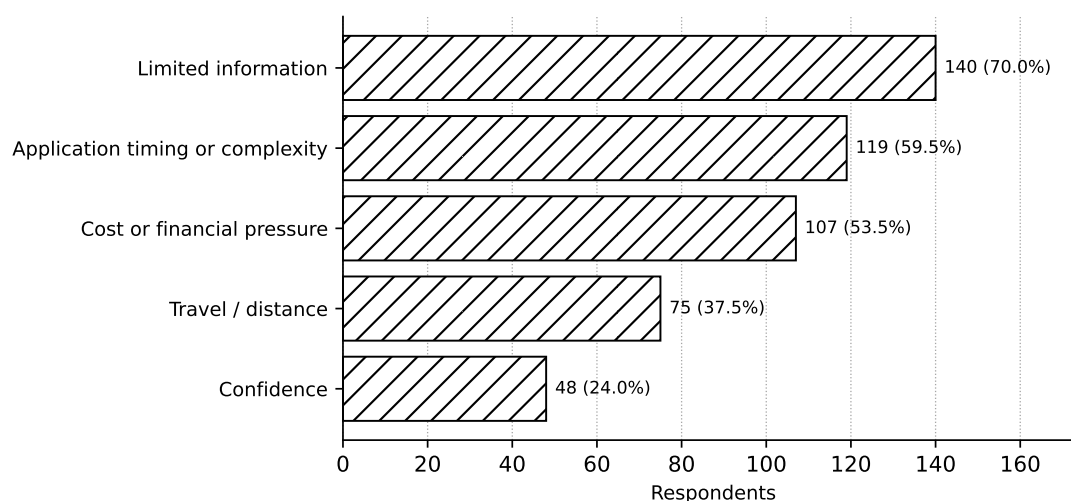


Figure 4: Selected barriers between pathway choice and entry

support networks and sometimes insider knowledge.

Respondents described the difficulty of tracking deadlines, forms and requirements. In coded qualitative responses, managing applications, forms and deadlines was one of the most common hardest-step themes. This suggests that many students do not only need a list of options. They need walkthroughs that show the process end-to-end.

A practical intervention should include:

- deadline maps for university, TAFE, apprenticeships, scholarships and local programs;
- application checklists by pathway type;
- examples of completed non-sensitive forms or application sections;
- guidance on common errors;
- reminders for key dates;
- a plain-English explanation of entry requirements and alternative entry routes.

This is where Pathway to Entry can add immediate value. It can translate complex institutional processes into youth-accessible instructions without replacing the institutions themselves.

5.3. Finding 3: cost pressure is a structural barrier

Cost or financial pressure was selected by 107 respondents, or 53.5 percent. Financial barriers should not be treated as a secondary concern. For regional young people, cost can include application costs, course materials, technology, tools, uniforms, travel, accommodation, relocation, missed work, unpaid placement, transport to interviews and uncertainty about income while studying.

The consultation also found that 89 respondents wanted financial support information. This is significant because many young people may not know which supports exist or how to access them. A scholarship, grant or concession that cannot be found at the right time does not function as a support.

The report therefore treats financial navigation as part of pathway navigation. Financial information should sit directly beside course and application information, not in a separate section that students must discover

later.

5.4. Finding 4: distance and exposure remain regional constraints

Travel or distance was selected by 75 respondents, or 37.5 percent. This result is lower than information, applications and cost, but it remains highly important because it is specifically regional. Distance affects open days, interviews, work placements, apprenticeships, campus visits, information nights, provider engagement, transport reliability and the ability to imagine a pathway as practically possible.

Distance also affects exposure. If a student cannot easily visit a workplace, meet employers, attend a campus, or speak with someone in the field, their decision-making becomes more abstract. This matters because exposure does not only provide information. It makes a pathway feel real.

The Regional Industry Education Partnerships program already recognises the value of employer-school connections by creating opportunities for employers to connect with secondary schools, allowing students to learn about jobs and pathways, develop networks and make informed career decisions [4]. Pathway to Entry should not duplicate that work. It should help young people find and use such opportunities, while also identifying local gaps.

5.5. Finding 5: confidence is real but downstream

Confidence was selected by 48 respondents, or 24.0 percent. This is a real barrier, but it should not be misunderstood as the main root cause. Confidence is often downstream of information, exposure, social capital and support. A young person is less likely to feel confident if they do not understand the process, cannot afford the transition, cannot reach the provider, has not met anyone like them in that pathway, or does not know whether they are making the right decision.

This distinction matters because confidence-building interventions can easily become shallow. A generic confidence workshop is less useful than a concrete application session, a mentoring conversation, a scholarship guide, or a visit to a workplace. Confidence grows when the path becomes legible.

6. Hardest Steps and Missing Supports

6.1. Hardest step in the pathway process

The qualitative coding shows that the hardest step was not one narrow action. Respondents described a cluster of transition tasks: finding reliable information, managing applications, working out costs, accessing open days or interviews, and building the confidence to apply.

Table 8: Coded hardest step in the pathway process

Category	n	% of respondents
Finding clear information and requirements	68	34.0%
Building confidence to apply	22	11.0%
Managing applications, forms and deadlines	63	31.5%
Working out cost, scholarships and grants	24	12.0%
Accessing open days, interviews and transport	23	11.5%

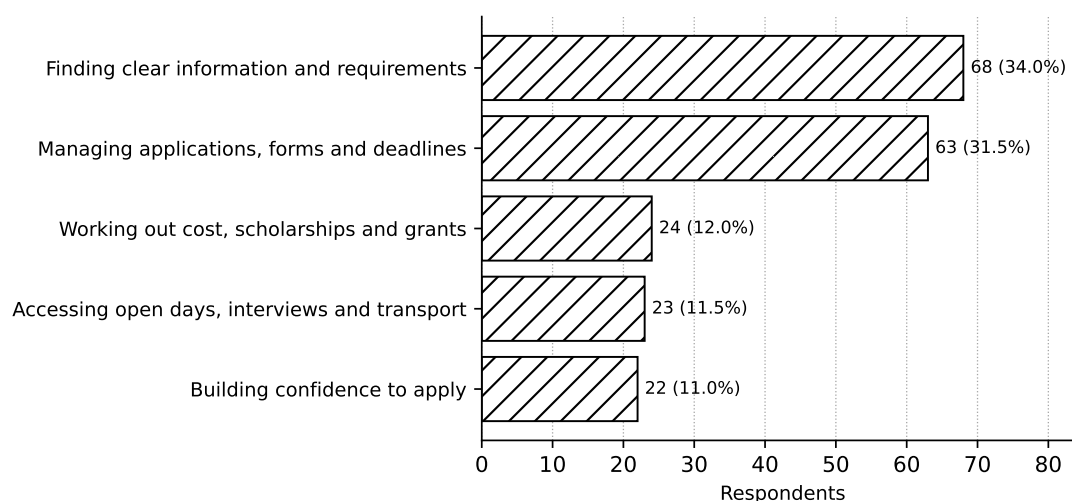


Figure 5: Coded hardest step in the pathway process

The two largest coded themes were finding clear information and managing applications, forms and deadlines. This confirms the quantitative barrier results. The strongest pain point is not abstract career choice. It is the practical process of getting from a decision to an actual application, enrolment, interview or entry point.

6.2. Requested supports

The support question provides the clearest design brief for Pathway to Entry. The strongest requested support was clearer timelines, selected by 142 respondents, or 71.0 percent. Employer or industry exposure was selected by 90 respondents. Financial support information was selected by 89 respondents. Application guidance was selected by 71 respondents. Transport or accommodation support was selected by 66 respondents. Mentoring or role models was selected by 44 respondents.

Table 9: Supports that would have made the biggest difference

Category	n	% of respondents
Clearer timelines	142	71.0%
Employer or industry exposure	90	45.0%
Financial support information	89	44.5%
Application guidance	71	35.5%
Transport or accommodation support	66	33.0%
Mentoring or role models	44	22.0%
Wellbeing support	1	0.5%

Respondents could select multiple supports, so percentages do not add to 100.

The support results are unusually actionable. They do not ask for vague inspiration. They ask for timelines, guidance, exposure, financial support information and practical access support. This gives Pathway to Entry a clear product and policy direction.

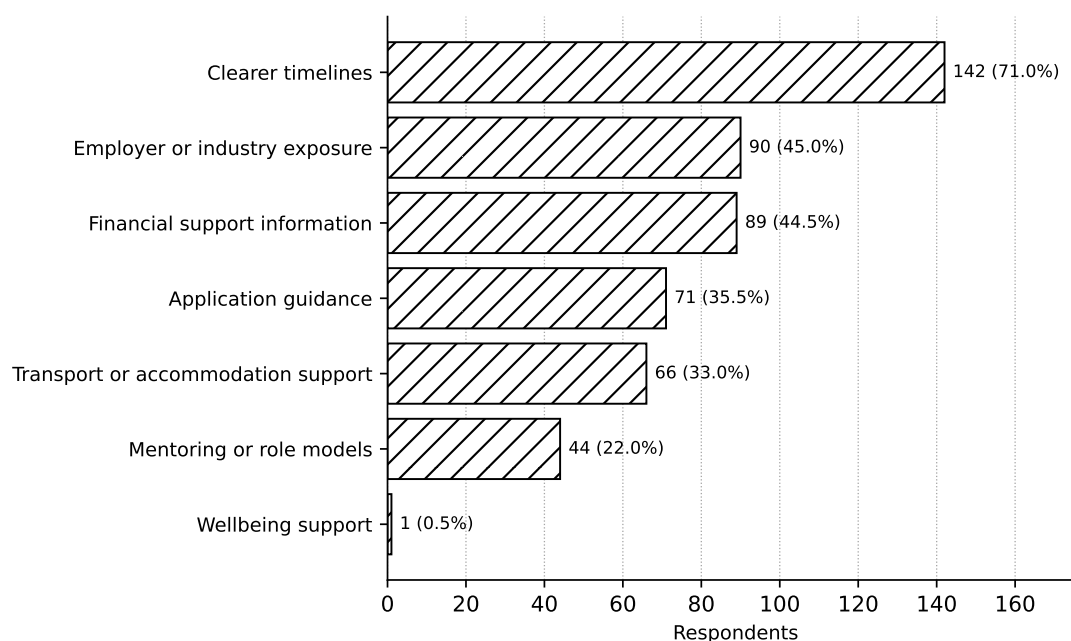


Figure 6: Requested supports

6.3. What respondents said was missing

Coded responses about missing support reinforce the same pattern. The most common missing-support theme was a central calendar or checklist of pathway steps. Application walkthroughs and industry exposure were also prominent.

Table 10: Coded missing support in current advice or guidance

Category	n	% of respondents
Travel and accommodation support	24	12.0%
Mentoring and role models	22	11.0%
Application walkthroughs and examples	36	18.0%
Financial support information	24	12.0%
Central calendar/checklist of pathway steps	58	29.0%
Workplace visits and industry exposure	36	18.0%

Representative anonymised responses include:

- “Finding clear, reliable information about what was actually required and by when was the most difficult step.”
- “The application process itself was the hardest — keeping track of different deadlines, forms, and requirements at the same time was overwhelming.”
- “Working out how to fund the transition was the hardest part — scholarships and grants were hard to find and the application process was confusing.”
- “Getting to open days and interviews was difficult because of the distance. Transport costs and time made it hard to explore options properly.”

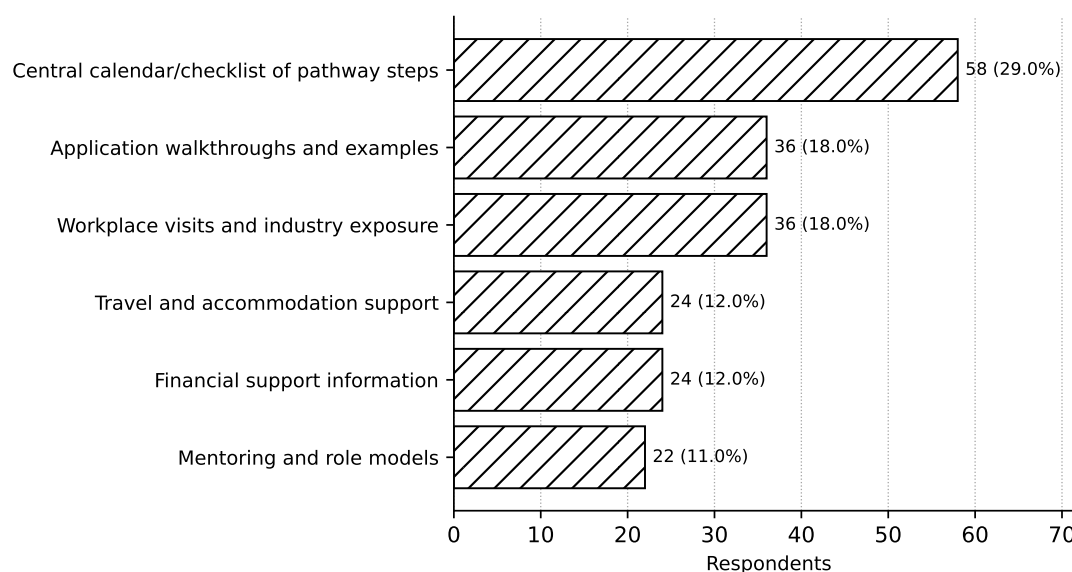


Figure 7: Coded missing support in current advice or guidance

- “A simple calendar or checklist showing key dates and steps for each pathway option would make a huge difference — currently everything is scattered across different websites.”
- “Connecting with someone who has been through a similar pathway and can share their experience honestly would be incredibly valuable.”

These responses are valuable because they convert broad categories into user language. The repeated phrase “scattered across different websites” captures the practical failure: the information may exist, but it is not experienced as a usable pathway.

7. Root Cause Analysis

7.1. Root cause 1: information exists but is not organised around the user

The consultation does not prove that institutions provide no information. In fact, the opposite is often true: there is too much information spread across too many places. The root cause is not pure absence. It is poor information architecture.

Young people encounter pathway information through school conversations, provider websites, social media, government pages, application portals, family advice, employer information and peer networks. Each source may be accurate in isolation. The failure occurs when the student must integrate all sources alone.

A youth-facing pathway system should therefore be organised around user tasks, not institutional categories. Instead of asking, “Which organisation owns this information?”, it should ask:

- What does the young person need to do next?
- What deadline matters?
- What documents are required?
- What will it cost?

- What support is available?
- Who can help?

7.2. Root cause 2: administrative burden is treated as personal responsibility

Applications, deadlines and eligibility rules are often treated as ordinary parts of post-school transition. But for many young people, especially those without strong family or school support, the administrative burden is a barrier in itself.

The application system assumes that students can track dates, compare requirements, understand terminology, gather documents, interpret entry schemes, assess financial implications, contact institutions, and correct mistakes. Students with higher social capital are more likely to have adults who can help. Students without that support experience the same system as harder, even if the formal rules are identical.

This is a social equity issue disguised as an administrative issue. A pathway navigator can reduce this by making hidden steps visible.

7.3. Root cause 3: financial information is separated from pathway advice

Course choice, training choice and career choice are often discussed separately from money. This is unrealistic. A pathway that cannot be financed is not a real option for the student at that time. Cost shapes whether a student can attend an open day, relocate, buy equipment, reduce work hours, complete unpaid placement, or accept a training opportunity.

The consultation shows that financial support information should be integrated into every pathway. A student considering TAFE should see fee information, concessions and support options. A student considering university should see scholarships, equity programs, accommodation costs and relocation supports. A student considering an apprenticeship should see travel, tools, employer expectations and income considerations.

7.4. Root cause 4: regional geography reduces exposure and increases risk

Regional students may have fewer chances to test pathways before committing. Distance can reduce access to campus visits, industry days, interviews, work experience and informal conversations with people in the field. This creates uncertainty and increases the perceived risk of choosing a pathway.

Geography also increases the cost of mistakes. A metropolitan student may have more nearby alternatives if a pathway changes. A regional student may have to relocate, travel long distances or reorganise work and family responsibilities. This makes early guidance more important, not less.

7.5. Root cause 5: confidence is affected by system legibility

Confidence should be understood as an outcome of system design. When the process is confusing, confidence falls. When the process is clear, confidence rises. When a young person has a mentor, a checklist, a deadline map and a realistic plan, the psychological barrier becomes smaller.

This is why the report does not recommend confidence-building as a standalone solution. Confidence should be built through practical competence. The strongest confidence intervention is a student leaving a session knowing exactly what to do next.

8. The Pathway to Entry Intervention Model

8.1. Strategic role

Pathway to Entry should be positioned as a transition-navigation layer. Its job is not to replace existing institutions. It should make the existing pathway system easier to use.

This positioning is strategically important. Schools, TAFE, universities, employers, councils, youth services and government programs already have roles. A youth-led project is unlikely to outperform each institution at its specialist task. It can, however, solve a different problem: the absence of a single youth-facing map that connects those tasks into a sequence.

8.2. Model component 1: central pathway calendar

The first product should be a calendar and checklist system. It should show key pathway dates for different options, including university applications, early entry, TAFE enrolment periods, apprenticeship intake periods, scholarship deadlines, open days, information nights and local events.

The calendar should be designed around student questions:

- What do I need to do this month?
- What deadlines are coming up?
- What should I prepare before I apply?
- Which options are still open?
- What should I do if I missed a deadline?

8.3. Model component 2: application walkthroughs

Pathway to Entry should develop application guides for the most common transition routes. These should not be vague advice pages. They should be practical walkthroughs with examples, checklists, common mistakes and contact points.

Priority walkthroughs should include:

1. university early entry and direct applications;
2. UAC or other tertiary application processes where relevant;
3. TAFE course search and enrolment;
4. apprenticeship and traineeship entry steps;
5. scholarship and financial support applications;
6. local employment and work experience pathways;
7. alternative entry, bridging and enabling options.

8.4. Model component 3: financial support navigator

The financial support navigator should centralise information about scholarships, grants, concessions, re-location supports, travel assistance, fee support, provider-specific supports and relevant government programs. It should be built as a pathway tool, not as a generic list.

The tool should answer:

- What support could apply to this pathway?
- When does it open and close?
- What documents are needed?
- Is it competitive, needs-based or automatic?
- Who can help complete it?

8.5. Model component 4: regional access guide

Regional access support should include practical information on transport, accommodation, open days, interviews, online alternatives, local support services and provider contacts. It should also identify where support is missing so that Pathway to Entry can advocate for improvements.

This component is particularly important for regional students whose pathway decisions involve travel or relocation. It should be developed with local knowledge rather than generic national advice.

8.6. Model component 5: exposure and mentoring

The consultation shows demand for employer and industry exposure, as well as mentoring and role models. Pathway to Entry should build a structured exposure model that connects young people with people who have navigated similar pathways.

This could include:

- near-peer talks from recent graduates, apprentices, trainees, TAFE students and university students;
- workplace visits and employer Q&A sessions;
- provider panels with TAFE, universities and training organisations;
- short recorded pathway stories;
- mentor matching for specific pathway questions.

8.7. Model component 6: referral and triage

Pathway to Entry should not attempt to solve every individual problem directly. Instead, it should triage and refer. If a student needs wellbeing support, financial counselling, disability support, career advice, provider admissions advice, apprenticeship support or local youth services, Pathway to Entry should help them find the right contact.

This referral role is essential because it protects the project from overreach. The project should be a navigation layer, not an unqualified counselling, admissions or welfare service.

9. Recommendations

9.1. Recommendations for Pathway to Entry

1. **Publish this report as the foundation document.** Use it as the evidence base for the website, partner conversations, school outreach and future grant applications.
2. **Build a public resource hub around timelines first.** The strongest requested support was clearer timelines, so the first website product should be a timeline and checklist system.
3. **Create pathway-specific application guides.** Prioritise university, TAFE, apprenticeships and traineeships, employment, scholarships and alternative entry.
4. **Develop a financial support directory.** Connect financial support directly to each pathway rather than publishing a disconnected list.
5. **Pilot workshops in regional schools and youth spaces.** Workshops should end with each participant identifying one concrete next action.
6. **Create a near-peer mentor database.** Start small, with verified volunteers who can answer pathway-specific questions.
7. **Measure action, not only engagement.** Track whether participants find a pathway, identify deadlines, start applications, attend events or contact providers.

9.2. Recommendations for schools

1. **Move from one-off careers advice to staged transition planning.** Students need repeated guidance across Years 10, 11 and 12, not only a late-stage conversation.
2. **Use pathway checklists in student meetings.** Every student should leave with clear next steps, not only broad encouragement.
3. **Treat financial and transport barriers as pathway issues.** These should be discussed early, before deadlines or opportunities are missed.
4. **Invite near-peer speakers and local employers.** Students need contact with people who have actually taken the pathway.
5. **Integrate families and carers where appropriate.** Parents and carers can support decisions more effectively when the process is clear.

9.3. Recommendations for providers

1. **Publish simpler pathway pages for regional students.** Course pages should link directly to application steps, dates, cost information and support contacts.
2. **Provide regional access information beside admissions information.** Transport, accommodation, online attendance and support options should be visible early.
3. **Offer more virtual and regional outreach options.** Open days should not be the only meaningful exposure point.

4. **Create plain-English application examples.** Worked examples reduce administrative anxiety and common mistakes.

9.4. Recommendations for employers and industry

1. **Offer short, structured exposure opportunities.** Workplace visits, Q&A sessions and career story panels can make pathways concrete.
2. **Explain entry steps clearly.** Students need to understand how apprenticeships, traineeships and entry-level roles are actually obtained.
3. **Partner with schools, councils and youth services.** Existing programs can be strengthened through local coordination.

9.5. Recommendations for government and community stakeholders

1. **Fund navigation infrastructure, not only destination programs.** A program is less useful if students cannot find or access it.
2. **Support local pathway coordinators and youth-led models.** Young people can help design resources that are more usable for their peers.
3. **Improve public visibility of financial supports.** Scholarships, concessions and travel supports should be searchable from a student perspective.
4. **Use linked pathway data to identify transition drop-off points.** NSW's Pathways for the Future Program already recognises the value of understanding end-to-end journeys and barriers to education and employment outcomes [5].

10. Implementation Roadmap

10.1. Stage 1: publication and stakeholder validation

The first stage should focus on credibility and validation. Pathway to Entry should publish the report, circulate it to relevant stakeholders, and request feedback from schools, youth services, TAFE, universities, employers, council contacts and state youth bodies.

Key deliverables:

- published report on pathwaytoentry.com;
- one-page executive brief;
- stakeholder email pack;
- short presentation version;
- feedback form for stakeholders;
- list of potential pilot partners.

10.2. Stage 2: minimum viable resource hub

The second stage should build the first practical resource set. The aim is not to build a perfect platform. The aim is to create enough value that young people, schools and partners can test it.

Minimum viable resources:

1. pathway calendar;
2. application checklist templates;
3. financial support directory;
4. regional access guide;
5. provider and local support contact page;
6. event and exposure opportunity list.

10.3. Stage 3: pilot workshops

The third stage should test the model through workshops. Each workshop should be practical and outcome-based. A successful session is not one where students merely listen. A successful session is one where students leave with a clearer pathway, a deadline, a support contact and one next action.

Suggested workshop modules:

- mapping your pathway options;
- understanding applications and deadlines;
- finding financial support;
- preparing for TAFE, university, apprenticeships or employment;
- regional access planning;
- building a personalised next-step checklist.

10.4. Stage 4: partner network

The fourth stage should formalise partnerships. This may include local schools, youth services, council, TAFE contacts, universities, industry groups, employers and volunteer mentors. The goal is to build a referral and exposure network that Pathway to Entry can coordinate.

The project should be careful not to overclaim formal partnerships. Early language should distinguish between confirmed partners, consulted stakeholders, potential collaborators and target stakeholders.

10.5. Stage 5: annual reporting

Pathway to Entry should publish an annual report after the pilot year. The annual report should include updated consultation data, resource usage, workshop attendance, stakeholder feedback, case studies, pathway actions completed and recommendations for policy or local service improvements.

This will turn the project into a repeatable evidence platform rather than a one-off report.

11. Evaluation Framework

11.1. Evaluation principles

Pathway to Entry should evaluate whether it reduces practical friction. Engagement metrics are useful, but they are not enough. Website views, social media reach and workshop attendance should be treated as early indicators, not final proof of impact.

The project should track whether young people become more capable of taking action. This means measuring clarity, confidence, application progress, support connections and pathway steps completed.

11.2. Suggested indicators

Table 11: Suggested evaluation indicators

Level	Indicator	Example measure
Input	Partner engagement	Number of schools, youth services, providers or employers engaged.
Input	Resource coverage	Number of pathways with published checklists and deadline guides.
Activity	Workshop delivery	Number of workshops, participants and locations.
Activity	Website usage	Views and downloads of timeline, application and financial support resources.
Output	Pathway clarity	Percentage of participants who can identify their next step after a session.
Output	Application readiness	Percentage of participants who know the relevant deadline and required documents.
Output	Support connection	Number of referrals made to schools, providers, youth services or mentors.
Outcome	Application action	Number of participants who start or complete an application, enrolment, enquiry or interview.
Outcome	Reduced uncertainty	Change in self-reported uncertainty before and after support.
Outcome	Stakeholder usefulness	Feedback from schools, providers and youth services on whether resources filled a gap.

11.3. Minimum data collection

Future consultation should collect:

- school year or post-school stage;
- local government area or broad region;
- pathway interest;
- current level of certainty;
- known deadlines;
- known supports;
- barriers ranked by severity;
- whether the respondent has completed key actions;
- post-support follow-up after one to three months.

This would allow Pathway to Entry to move from consultation evidence to impact evidence.

12. Conclusion

The Pathway to Entry consultation shows a consistent and practical problem. Young people are not only asking for motivation. They are asking for a clearer map. They want timelines, application guidance, financial support information, transport and accommodation support, employer exposure and mentoring. These are not abstract requests. They are the missing infrastructure between choosing a pathway and reaching entry.

The strongest result was limited information. The strongest requested support was clearer timelines. Together, these findings create a simple mandate: Pathway to Entry should make the transition process legible.

The project's credibility will depend on discipline. It should avoid overclaiming, avoid duplicating existing services, and avoid pretending that a youth-led website can solve every structural barrier. Its value lies in connection, translation and navigation. It can help young people understand what exists, what matters now, what comes next, and who can help.

If implemented properly, Pathway to Entry can become a serious regional transition project: one that turns consultation into resources, resources into action, and action into stronger evidence for policy and service improvement.

A. Detailed Tables

This appendix provides the core aggregate results used throughout the report. Percentages are calculated out of 200 valid consented responses unless otherwise stated.

B. Survey Instrument Summary

The consultation survey included the following fields:

1. age group;

Table 12: Appendix table: age group

Category	n	% of respondents
16–18	50	25.0%
18–23	94	47.0%
Educator / stakeholder	31	15.5%
Prefer not to say	25	12.5%

Table 13: Appendix table: region

Category	n	% of respondents
Regional NSW	118	59.0%
Other / Interstate	72	36.0%
Metro NSW	10	5.0%

Table 14: Appendix table: current situation

Category	n	% of respondents
TAFE	65	32.5%
University	63	31.5%
Employed (not in training)	51	25.5%
Recent graduate (last 2 years)	8	4.0%
Year 11	7	3.5%
Year 12	5	2.5%
Gap year	1	0.5%

Table 15: Appendix table: pathway decision status

Category	n	% of respondents
Yes	114	57.0%
Unsure	75	37.5%
No	11	5.5%

Table 16: Appendix table: selected pathway type

Category	n	% of respondents
TAFE	45	22.5%
University	41	20.5%
Employment	27	13.5%
Not sure	1	0.5%
No response	86	43.0%

Table 17: Appendix table: selected barriers

Category	n	% of respondents
Limited information	140	70.0%
Application timing or complexity	119	59.5%
Cost or financial pressure	107	53.5%
Travel / distance	75	37.5%
Confidence	48	24.0%

Multi-select question. Totals exceed 100 percent.

Table 18: Appendix table: requested supports

Category	n	% of respondents
Clearer timelines	142	71.0%
Employer or industry exposure	90	45.0%
Financial support information	89	44.5%
Application guidance	71	35.5%
Transport or accommodation support	66	33.0%
Mentoring or role models	44	22.0%
Wellbeing support	1	0.5%

Multi-select question. Totals exceed 100 percent.

Table 19: Appendix table: coded hardest step

Category	n	% of respondents
Finding clear information and requirements	68	34.0%
Building confidence to apply	22	11.0%
Managing applications, forms and deadlines	63	31.5%
Working out cost, scholarships and grants	24	12.0%
Accessing open days, interviews and transport	23	11.5%

Table 20: Appendix table: coded missing support

Category	n	% of respondents
Travel and accommodation support	24	12.0%
Mentoring and role models	22	11.0%
Application walkthroughs and examples	36	18.0%
Financial support information	24	12.0%
Central calendar/checklist of pathway steps	58	29.0%
Workplace visits and industry exposure	36	18.0%

2. region;
3. current situation;
4. whether the respondent had chosen a pathway after school;
5. chosen pathway type, if applicable;
6. biggest barriers between choosing a pathway and reaching entry;
7. hardest step in the pathway process;
8. supports that would have made the biggest difference;
9. what is missing in current advice or support;
10. consent to use views and ideas to inform the project.

The design combined structured questions with short written responses. This allowed the analysis to identify both quantified barrier prevalence and recurring explanatory themes.

C. Coding Notes

The qualitative coding used simple thematic categories. The coding did not attempt to produce a full academic grounded-theory analysis. Its purpose was to convert recurring written responses into practical design categories for Pathway to Entry.

Hardest-step responses were coded into:

- finding clear information and requirements;
- managing applications, forms and deadlines;
- working out cost, scholarships and grants;
- accessing open days, interviews and transport;
- building confidence to apply.

Missing-support responses were coded into:

- central calendar or checklist of pathway steps;
- application walkthroughs and examples;
- workplace visits and industry exposure;
- travel and accommodation support;
- financial support information;
- mentoring and role models.

Future reports should improve this process by collecting longer free-text responses, conducting interviews or focus groups, and using two independent coders to improve reliability.

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